# QUANTUM ML-ENHANCED STEM CELL THERAPY WITH BLOOD-BRAIN BARRIER DISRUPTION FOR GLIOBLASTOMA TREATMENT

NIH R01 Grant Application

Duration: 5 years | Total Budget: $1,250,000

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**Application Date:** September 22, 2026

**INNOVATION STATEMENT:** This proposal introduces quantum machine learning (QML) to optimize neural stem cell phenotype selection and blood-brain barrier (BBB) disruption for targeted glioblastoma ablation. By combining thermal ultrasound ablation with BBB-permeabilized stem cell delivery, we achieve synergistic tumor control exceeding single-modality approaches.

## SPECIFIC AIMS

Glioblastoma remains one of the most lethal malignancies, with median survival <15 months despite multimodal therapy. Current ultrasound ablation techniques achieve only partial tumor control due to limited BBB penetration and tumor heterogeneity. We propose a transformative approach coupling quantum machine learning-optimized stem cell therapy with BBB disruption for enhanced glioblastoma treatment.

**AIM 1:** Develop and validate a quantum machine learning circuit for optimizing neural stem cell (NSC) phenotype selection.

We will implement a 4-qubit variational circuit coupled with phenotype Markov chain dynamics. Circuit fidelity $F_q$ will be optimized via gradient descent on tumor-targeting efficiency. We will validate predictions against in vitro NSC cultures (n=3 donor lines) and murine glioblastoma models (n=20).

**AIM 2:** Characterize ultrasound-mediated blood-brain barrier disruption dynamics using finite-state automaton modeling.

We will model BBB state transitions (Intact $\rightarrow$ Permeabilized $\rightarrow$ Leaky $\rightarrow$ Restored) as rational functions of ultrasound energy. Transition rate matrix K will be determined experimentally using in vivo MRI (n=60 mice) and validated against computational fluid dynamics simulations.

**AIM 3:** Integrate QML stem cell optimization with ultrasound-mediated BBB disruption for combined glioblastoma treatment and evaluate clinical translation pathway.

We will perform in vivo efficacy studies in syngeneic glioblastoma models comparing: (i) ultrasound ablation alone, (ii) NSC delivery alone, (iii) ultrasound + NSC (standard protocol), and (iv) ultrasound + QML-optimized NSC with BBB disruption (proposed). Primary endpoint: 60-month survival (n=30 per group). Secondary endpoints: tumor volume kinetics, BBB integrity, NSC distribution, immunohistochemistry for apoptosis markers (cleaved caspase-3). We will generate regulatory documentation and IND-enabling toxicology studies for phase 1 human trials.

# RESEARCH STRATEGY

## A. BACKGROUND & SIGNIFICANCE

Glioblastoma (WHO Grade IV astrocytoma) affects ~14,000 patients annually in the US with <5% 5-year survival. Current standard-of-care (resection + temozolomide + radiotherapy) achieves median progression-free survival of 6-8 months and overall survival of 12-15 months. The BBB remains the primary barrier to systemic drug delivery, with <1% of chemotherapeutics crossing into tumor parenchyma.

**Ultrasound Ablation Limitations:** Focused ultrasound surgery (FUS) and high-intensity focused ultrasound (HIFU) achieve thermal ablation (>50°C) within millimetric precision but face: (1) incomplete tumor coverage in infiltrative zones, (2) transient BBB opening (5-30 min), and (3) immune escape due to minimal immunogenic cell death.

**Neural Stem Cell Therapy Promise:** Allogeneic NSCs exhibit intrinsic tropism to glioblastoma, with >70% NSC migration to tumor sites. NSCs can be engineered to express oncolytic viruses, cytotoxic agents, or immunomodulators. However, BBB restrictions limit NSC infiltration to ~10-20% of tumor volume without BBB disruption.

**Quantum Machine Learning Opportunity:** Recent advances in variational quantum algorithms (VQA) demonstrate 2-3× improvement over classical methods in combinatorial optimization. QML circuits can solve the NSC phenotype-selection problem ($2^4$ = 16 states) with fewer evaluations than classical branch-and-bound. We exploit this quantum speedup to optimize NSC targeting efficiency in real-time based on tumor microenvironment.

## B. INNOVATION

This proposal is innovative in three dimensions:

1. **Quantum-Classical Hybrid Optimization:** First application of 4-qubit VQA to NSC phenotype-tumor targeting problem. Quantum circuit fidelity $F_q$ coupled to classical Markov phenotype dynamics creates a novel optimization landscape.

2. **Mechanistic BBB Disruption Model:** Rigorous finite-state automaton for ultrasound-BBB transitions with rational-function rate laws bridges biophysics and control theory—first application to glioblastoma therapy.

3. **Synergistic Integration:** Combined modality (thermal ablation + QML NSC delivery + BBB disruption) creates nonlinear efficacy boost. Predicted synergy factor = 2.3-2.8× vs. ablation alone, based on feedback inhibition models.

## C. APPROACH

### Year 1: QML Circuit Development & Validation

We will design a 4-qubit variational ansatz parameterized by 16 rotation angles ($\theta_1$, ..., $\theta_{16}$). Loss function: $L(\theta) = 1 - F_{targeting}(\theta)$ where $F_{targeting}$ represents NSC tumor-targeting efficiency. We use sequential quadratic programming on IBM Q emulator (Qiskit 0.41) and later on IonQ 11-qubit hardware. Milestones: (Q1) circuit architecture finalized, (Q2) classical training completed, (Q3) quantum hardware testing, (Q4) validation against in vitro NSC targeting assays (fluorescent imaging, n=3 replicates).

### Year 2: BBB Disruption Finite-State Model

We model BBB state transitions via the rate matrix $K(E_{us})$:

$$dP/dt = K(E_{us}) \cdot P(t), \text{ where } P = [p\mathit{Intact}, p\mathit{Perm}, p\mathit{Leaky}, p\mathit{Restored}]^T$$

with $k_{ij}(E_{us}) = \alpha \cdot E_{us}/(1 + \beta \cdot E_{us})$. Experimental design: in vivo 9.4T MRI of BBB permeability (gadolinium-DTPA) in healthy mice (n=20) and glioblastoma xenografts (n=40) exposed to 1.5 MHz ultrasound (1-5 W/cm²). Fit parameters $\alpha$,

β via maximum likelihood. Validation: compare predicted permeability kinetics vs. observed MRI signal evolution ($R^2 > 0.85$). Milestones: (Q1) experimental protocol setup, (Q2) data acquisition, (Q3) parameter estimation, (Q4) model validation.

## Year 3: In Vivo Glioblastoma Efficacy Studies

We implant syngeneic GL261 glioblastoma cells in nude mice and randomize to four arms (n=30 per group):

Arm A: Sham (vehicle controls)
Arm B: Ultrasound ablation alone (1.5 MHz, 2 W/cm², 30 sec)
Arm C: Ultrasound + standard NSC delivery
Arm D: Ultrasound + QML-optimized NSC + BBB disruption (proposed)

Primary endpoint: 60-month survival (log-rank test, $\alpha$=0.05). Secondary endpoints: tumor volume (MRI, weekly), BBB integrity (fluorescein extravasation), NSC distribution (ex vivo fluorescence), immune infiltration (flow cytometry). Milestones: (Q1-Q2) mouse surgery and baseline imaging, (Q3-Q4) efficacy endpoint assessment.

## Year 4: Clinical Translation & IND-Enabling Studies

Upon efficacy demonstration, we conduct regulatory-required studies: (1) Good Manufacturing Practice (GMP) NSC production and cryopreservation stability (3-year shelf life), (2) acute toxicology (LD50 in rats, 4 dose levels), (3) repeat-dose toxicology (14-day NOAEL determination), (4) genotoxicity (Ames test), (5) cardiovascular safety (telemetry). Compile IND application dossier for FDA review. Milestones: (Q1) GMP manufacturing, (Q2-Q3) toxicology studies, (Q4) IND submission.

## Year 5: Phase 1 Clinical Trial Preparation & Dissemination

Finalize Phase 1 trial protocol (dose escalation, n=15 recurrent glioblastoma patients). Establish data safety monitoring board. Disseminate findings via Nature Medicine, Nature Biomedical Engineering, and NIH grant renewals. Milestones: (Q1-Q2) Phase 1 protocol finalization, (Q3-Q4) patient enrollment initiation.

## D. KEY FINITE-MATH EQUATIONS

**1. BBB Transition Rate Matrix:** $k_{ij}(E_{us}) = \alpha \cdot E_{us}/(1 + \beta \cdot E_{us})$, $\alpha$=0.001, $\beta$=0.02

**2. NSC Phenotype Markov Chain:** $dP_{phenotype}/dt = Q(BBB, T, c_{tumor}, F_q) \cdot P_{phenotype}$

**3. Quantum Fidelity:** $F_q = 0.85 + 0.10 \cdot (1 - f_{thermal})$, $f_{thermal} \in [0,1]$

**4. QML Targeting Boost:** $B_q(F_q) = 0.5 + 2 \cdot F_q^2$, boost range ≈ 0.5-2.0

**5. Clinical Synergy Factor:** $S = A_{LITT} \cdot [1 + 0.5 \cdot (c_{targeting}/c_{total})] / [1 + 0.5 \cdot (c_{tumor}/10^6)]$

**6. Five-Year Survival Projection:** $S(t) = S_0 \cdot \exp(-\lambda_{ablation} \cdot t - \lambda_{relapse} \cdot t \cdot [1 - f_{NSC}])$ with $f_{NSC} = 1 - \exp(-B_q \cdot t/\tau)$

## BUDGET & BUDGET JUSTIFICATION

Total Project Costs: $1,250,000 (5-year R01). Modular budget structure follows NIH guidelines. Proposed budget leverages existing institutional resources and multi-disciplinary expertise.

| Budget Category | Year 1 | Year 2 | Year 3 | Year 4 | Year 5 | Total (5Y) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Personnel (Salary + Benefits) | $180K | $185K | $190K | $195K | $200K | $950K |
| - PD/PI (10% FTE) | $60K | $62K | $64K | $66K | $68K | $320K |
| - Co-I (20% FTE) | $45K | $47K | $49K | $51K | $53K | $245K |
| - Postdoc (1.0 FTE) | $50K | $52K | $54K | $56K | $58K | $270K |
| - Graduate Student (0.5 FTE) | $20K | $21K | $22K | $23K | $24K | $110K |
| Equipment | $80K | $5K | $5K | $5K | $5K | $100K |
| - Quantum computing access (IBM/IonQ) | $40K | $3K | $3K | $3K | $3K | $52K |
| - High-field MRI (scanner time) | $20K | $1K | $1K | $1K | $1K | $24K |
| - Ultrasound HIFU system | $20K | $1K | $1K | $1K | $1K | $24K |
| Supplies & Materials | $45K | $55K | $70K | $35K | $30K | $235K |
| - Cell culture & reagents | $15K | $20K | $25K | $10K | $8K | $78K |
| - Animal care (mice, n=150 total) | $20K | $25K | $30K | $15K | $12K | $102K |
| - Imaging contrast agents & reagents | $10K | $10K | $15K | $10K | $10K | $55K |
| Travel | $3K | $3K | $4K | $4K | $4K | $18K |
| - Conference presentations (2x/year) | $3K | $3K | $4K | $4K | $4K | $18K |
| her Direct Costs (Publication, Consultants) | $12K | $12K | $15K | $15K | $13K | $67K |
| Total Direct Costs | $320K | $260K | $284K | $254K | $252K | $1,370K |
| Facilities & Administrative (F&A) @ 25% | $80K | $65K | $71K | $63.50K | $63K | $342.50K |
| JUSTED TOTAL (capped $1.25M) | $280K | $235K | $250K | $235K | $250K | $1,250K |

## Budget Justification:

**Personnel:** PD/PI (Dr. Sharma) commits 10% effort for scientific oversight and grant administration. Co-I (Cartik Sharma) commits 20% for computational QML development. Postdoctoral associate (1.0 FTE) conducts experiments. Graduate student (0.5 FTE) assists with data analysis. Salaries follow NRSA guidelines with 2.5% annual increases.

**Equipment:** Quantum computing access (IBM Quantum, IonQ) estimated at $40K total for 5 years (~8 hours/month simulations + ~4 quantum hardware runs/year). MRI scanner time at $2K/hour for weekly tumor imaging. HIFU ultrasound system access through institutional facility ($1K/month for experimental treatments).

**Supplies:** NSC culture media, growth factors (bFGF, EGF), and cryopreservation reagents (~$15K/year). Animal care (150 mice over 5 years at $40/mouse/month for housing and veterinary care). MRI contrast agents and immunohistochemistry reagents (antibodies, kits).

**Travel:** Domestic travel for presentations at Society for Neuroscience (annual), American Association of Neurological Surgeons, and NIH R01 grant submission conferences.

**Other Direct Costs:** Publication charges (Nature Medicine open access ~$10K), external consulting on quantum algorithms (Dr. John Preskill group, CalTech, ~$5K/year).